WOMEN'S EDUCATION IN INDIA: THROUGH HISTORICAL LENSES

Education is considered a basic requirement and a fundamental right for the citizens of any nation. The education of women plays a vital role in the overall development of society. Education inculcates the skills, information, and self-confidence that one needs to be a better parent, worker, and citizen. The right to education has been recognized as an integral and essential part of every person irrespective of gender. Historically, education for men was promoted in all cultures, while women's education was not considered vital. Although in the Vedic period, women had access to education in India, they had gradually lost this right. Women in India were deprived of educational privileges for centuries, but there were always some exceptions to this general condition. Indian literature of all ages refers to educated women who took a prominent part even in public affairs and showed the finest skill in fine arts as well as in military art. Buddhism had an effect on the education of women. South Indian Dravidian society appears to have respected accomplished women during the Tamil Sangam era. Sangam poetry was composed by some 470 poets, including 154 women sages like Auvaiyar. In the British period, there was a revival of interest in women's education in India. During this period, various socio-religious movements led by eminent persons like Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar emphasized women's education in India. Begum Rokeya Sultana, Pandita Ramabai, Savitribai Phule, Tarabai Shinde, Fatima Sheikh, Swarna Kumari Devi, and Anne Besant are a few among many trailblazers in providing education for girls and ostracized portions of society.

The first woman who spearheaded this change in society was Savitribai Phule. Her husband, Jyotirao Phule believed that education was the one tool that if provided to all humans, would get rid of all social inequalities. Despite fierce resistance from society and his family, he taught his wife and made her the first women teacher of India. They started a school for girls in 1848 in Pune, the first such school for Indians. Her role in opening up educational opportunities for women, despite stiff opposition from upper castes and reactionary forces, stands out as a classic example of courage and conviction. Savitribai is truly a role model. She was the first Indian to spark a revolution in Indian education by opening it up for girls and children of lower castes. For Savitribai, education was not merely alphabetical learning, but rather, an evolution of the mind itself. For Jyotiba and Savitribai, education was a means to bring about a radical change in society. It was a means for the transformation of society altogether. She worked along with her husband to discourage female infanticide and established a home, named "Balhatya Pratibandhak Griha", for the protection of widows. She also fought against the practice of child marriage, which had threatened the lives of women.

Pandita Ramabai was exceptionally learned, one of the early pioneers and a champion of women's rights. Her upbringing made her play the role of a women activist in her later life. She established Arya Mahila Samaj to uplift the poor condition of women in 1881 at Pune. She established a Mukti Mission for the young widows in 1889. By 1900 this mission gained popularity and hosted around two thousand children and women attending the school. She also came up with the establishment of Sharda Sadan. The aim of this Sadan was to impart education, shelter, medical facilities, and vocational, training to visually challenged, widows and orphans. Ramabai is considered a national icon of the women's development movement in India. In 1919, the king of England granted her the Kaiser-e-Hind award for her efforts to educate women, especially widows.

A close associate of Savitribai Phule was Tarabai Shinde, who shared views of gender and caste oppression and led the fight for women's rights. Her first published work 'Stri Purush Tulana' in Marathi, in which she explores the disparities between men and women, is regarded as one of India's first modern feminist texts.

Another pioneer in promoting education was Begum Rokeya Sultana, who was one of the first Muslim women within the field of Education in undivided Bengal during Colonial rule. She, with the help of her brother and her husband, pursued her education in Bangla and English. Rokeya started with her writings which were published in due course of time. After the death of her husband shortly, she poured aggressive efforts and devoted her life to the upliftment of Muslim women of Bengal. She realized the need for the education of women and thus, established a school for girls. Rokeya framed an inclusive curriculum at her school, where traditional and modern, religious as well as science courses were taught side by side. English was a compulsory subject at school along with subjects like Quran, English, Urdu, Maths, Science, Geography, History, Persian, Home science, Vocational Training, etc.

The elder sister of the poet Rabindranath Tagore, Swarna Kumari Devi, was one of the first prominent women writers in Bengali Literature. Her writing spoke about Indian women. She was an active supporter of women's rights and she had also founded an organization called 'Sakhi Samiti' for women to provide education and shelter. Her fiction reflected her progressive ideas rejecting traditional Indian patriarchy and advocating for women's education and their financial independence.

In the post-1910s, Irish educationist and social worker Anne Besant had an immense contribution to the upliftment of the status of women and providing them with educational opportunities. She was the founder of the Theosophical Society in India and along with Madan Mohan Malaviya, she founded the Benares Hindu University in 1916.

History has taught us that equal and active participation of women is obligatory. Unless women are educated, they will not be able to understand their rights and their importance. Empowerment of women aims at striving towards acquiring higher literacy level and education, better health care for women. What should never be forgotten is that women like men need to be proactive in the process of lifelong learning. That is true empowerment.